

FRED TALKS

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Thoughts and Feelings around Claude Design

SAMHENRI.GOLD · 19 APR 2026 · [SOURCE](#)



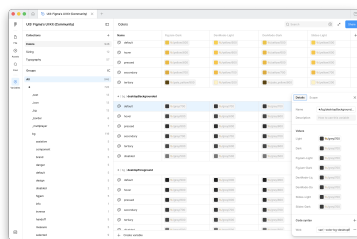
I tried [Claude Design](#) yesterday and I have a theory for how this whole thing shakes out.

As product teams scaled and design needed to justify itself inside engineering orgs, it was pushed toward systematization — and Figma invented its own primitives to make that work: components, styles, variables, props, and so on. Some concepts are borrowed from programming, some aren't, and the whole thing doesn't neatly map onto anything. Guidance evolves, migrations pile up, and if you want to automate any of it you're stuck with a handful of shoddy plugins. The beast is hairy enough that entire design roles now specialize in wrangling the system itself.

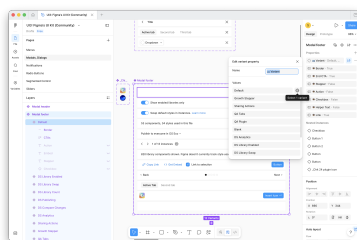
There's always been a tense push-pull between Figma and code over what the source of truth should be. Figma won over Sketch partially by staking its claim there — their tooling would be canonical.

That victory had a hidden cost. By nature of having a locked-down, largely-undocumented format that's painful to work with programmatically, Figma accidentally excluded themselves from the training data that would have made them relevant in the agentic era. LLMs were trained on code, not Figma primitives, so models never learned them. As code becomes easier for designers to write and agents keep improving, the source of truth will naturally migrate back to code. And all the baroque infrastructure Figma had to introduce over the past decade will look nuts by comparison. Why fuss around in a lossy approximation of the thing when you can work directly in the medium where it will actually live? If we want to make pottery, why are we painting watercolors of the pot instead of just throwing the clay?

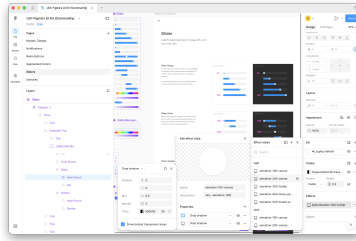
At work, we've spent quite a bit of time back-porting design changes made directly in code back to Figma and it is not fun. I can't share that file, but for a fair comparison, this is Figma's own design system file for their product. I have to assume it was built by the most competent design system team you can find. And yet...



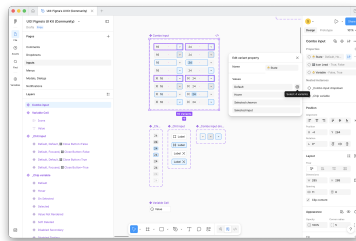
The Figma variables panel showing 946 color variables organized into nested groups like "bg/desktopBackgrounded," with a single selected variable revealing eight mode-specific values: Light, Dark, FigJam-Light, FigJam-Dark, DevMode-Light, DevMode-Dark, Slides-Light, and Slides-Dark.



A modal footer component open to its variant property editor, showing 12 variants with a dropdown full of values like "DS Library Swap," "QA Plugin," "Growth Stepper," and "Sharing Actions." The right panel lists eight props like "Border," "Second CTA," and "Helper Text"



The effect styles panel for a slider component, showing a style named "light/elevation-300-tooltip." Expanding it reveals its entire definition: a 0.5px drop shadow at 30% black. It has its own named style because that's the only way to document what CSS variable it corresponds to.



A combo input component with 16 variants. Its children in the layers panel are named things like "Default, Default, Close Button=False" and "Default, Focused, Close Button=True"

These are Figma's own files. Built by their own team. This is the gold standard.

Imagine debugging a color that looks wrong. You check the component. The component uses a variable. The variable is aliased to another variable. That variable references a mode. The mode is overridden at the instance level. The instance lives inside a nested component with a library swap applied. At this point, you're either considering picking up code or moving to the countryside and becoming a sheep farmer because one more minute of this will make you lose your goddamn mind.

So as the source of truth shifts back to code, Figma is left in an odd spot: holding a largely manual, pre-agentic system that nobody in their right mind would design from scratch today.

I think design tooling forks into two distinct shapes from here — and there's almost a clock resetting between Figma and every other tool competing to answer the same question they answered in 2016: who can help me, a designer, get my ideas out fastest?

Spoiler: it's not Figma Make. Figma Make feels like it primarily benefits people who have already drunk the Kool-Aid — it reads from Figma styles, component libraries, and proprietary props (or, as I like to call them, Prop Props), and it's the only tool in this new landscape still pretending the design file is canonical. It's the tool for people who want to (or have no choice but to) stay inside the system.

Claude Design is the first of those two tools, and takes the opposite bet. There's an Arts and Crafts principle called "truth to materials" — the idea that a thing should be honest about what it is and how it's made, rather than masquerading as something else. Figma ended up being the opposite of this: a set of extremely rigid schemas with a free-form "just vibes, man" costume over the top. Like a Type-A personality physically incapable of relaxing, forced to perform chill while internally screaming that your frames aren't nested and your tokens are detached and nothing is on the grid. Claude Design, for all its roughness, is at least honest about what it is: HTML and JS all the way down.



A Gustav Stickley lamp table, circa 1902. The joinery is exposed, not hidden. The wood is the wood.

And it has a massive structural advantage: its sibling is Claude Code. Eventually, I can see Claude Design just dumping things directly into Claude Code and vice versa. Claude Design's onboarding already lets you import your repos. The feedback loop between design and implementation — which has been a source of friction since the beginning of time — becomes a single conversation.

The other tool that emerges from this moment will have no expectation of code at all. It'll be a pure exploration environment — somewhere to drop rectangles, stack layer styles, fuss with blend modes and gradients, and go completely nuts, unconstrained by systems or prompting conventions. Maybe it's an iPad app with Pencil support where you just quickly sketch a bunch of rectangles. 37signals could do something really funny right now. Or maybe it goes in the opposite direction — something more like Photoshop that goes all-in on high-fidelity compositing and lets our imaginations run wild, now that we're no longer beholden to the ceiling of what you can do with CSS effects. Doesn't it seem *kinda weird* how for 90% of its life, Figma's only layer effect was a drop shadow or a blur?

Figma's Sketch moment is rapidly approaching. And if you said that sentence to a Victorian child, they would probably have a stroke.

Post Script

The following are messages meant only for the teams behind Sketch and Figma. If neither apply to you, you can skedaddle.

To Figma: I can see a world where this post does numbers in the Figma internal Slack. If that's the case and you're reading this from Figma: this wouldn't have happened if you hired me last year when I was interviewing. Your loss, big dawg.

To Sketch: GET YOUR HEADS OUTTA YOUR ASSES AND GIVE EM HELL. ADD PARTICLE EFFECTS. ADD DEBOSSING EFFECTS. MESH TRANSFORMS. FUCK IT, ADD METAL SHADERS. GO NUTS. STOP COASTING OFF OF BEING MAC NATIVE. QUIT DRINKING COCOA AND GET THIRSTY FOR BLOOD.

To mom: Sorry for cursing.

Post-Post Script

[@jonnyburch](#) on Twitter shared a link to [their blog post](#) with similar thoughts, it's quite good if you wanna go deeper.

[Daily article] April 20: Sci-Fi Dine-In Theater Restaurant

ENGLISH WIKIPEDIA ARTICLE OF THE DAY · 20 APR 2026 · [SOURCE](#)

The Sci-Fi Dine-In Theater Restaurant is a theme restaurant at Disney's Hollywood Studios, a theme park at Walt Disney World in Bay Lake, Florida. The restaurant is modeled after a 1950s drive-in theater. Walt Disney Imagineering designed the booths to resemble convertibles of the period. While eating, guests watch a large projection screen displaying clips from films such as *Frankenstein Meets the Space Monster*, *Plan 9 from Outer Space*, and *Attack of the 50 Foot Woman*. In 1991, the Sci-Fi Dine-In opened along with nineteen other new Walt Disney World attractions marking the complex's twentieth anniversary. By the following year, it had become

the park's most popular restaurant. Thai movie theater operator EGV Entertainment opened the EGV Drive-in Cafe in Bangkok in 2003, explicitly emulating the Sci-Fi Dine-In. USA Today's list of the best restaurants in American amusement parks ranks the Sci-Fi Dine-In fifteenth, but many reviewers rate it more highly for its atmosphere than its cuisine. (Full article...).

Read more: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sci-Fi_Dine-In_Theater_Restaurant

Today's selected anniversaries:

1809:

War of the Fifth Coalition: Commanded by Napoleon, Franco- German forces defeated a reinforced Austrian corps at the Battle of Abensberg. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Battle_of_Abensberg

1914:

A fire and a gun battle between the Colorado National Guard and striking coal miners led to 17 deaths in the Ludlow Massacre. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Ludlow_Massacre

1922:

The Soviet government created the South Ossetian Autonomous Oblast within the Georgian SSR. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/South_Ossetian_Autonomous_Oblast

1939:

Billie Holiday recorded the song "Strange Fruit", which later became an emblem of the civil rights movement. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Strange_Fruit

2021:

Derek Chauvin was found guilty of all charges in the murder of George Floyd by a Minnesota court. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Trial_of_Derek_Chauvin

Wiktionary's word of the day:

tang ping: 1. (China, neologism) A lifestyle and social protest movement in China beginning in April 2021, which is a rejection of societal pressures to overwork. 2. About Word of the Day 3. Nominate a word 4. Leave feedback https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/tang_ping

Wikiquote quote of the day:

Don't look back, and don't run. You must never run from anything immortal; it attracts their attention. --Peter S. Beagle https://en.wikiquote.org/wiki/Peter_S._Beagle

Wisereads Vol. 139 — Laziness as a virtue, Anthropic's Mythos, and more

HELLO@READWISE.IO (READWISE) · 20 APR 2026 · [SOURCE](#)

Last week, we shared a preview of *The Book of Delights* by Ross Gay, a collection of essays that look for the wonder in everyday life. This week, we're sharing the autobiography of aviation legend Charles Lindbergh, a recent addition to the Standard Ebooks catalog.

Keep reading to add to your Reader account below 📌

Most highlighted Articles of the week



Mythos, Muse, and the Opportunity Cost of Compute

Ben Thompson · Stratechery

Stratechery's Ben Thompson argues that the era of consumer tech growth driven by zero marginal costs is giving way to one shaped by opportunity cost. "It's opportunity costs, not marginal costs, that are the challenge facing hyperscalers. How much compute should go to customers, and which ones? How much should be reserved for internal workloads? Microsoft needs to balance Azure — both for its enterprise customers and OpenAI — and its software

business; Amazon needs to balance its e-commerce business, AWS, and its strategic investments in both Anthropic and OpenAI. Google has to balance GCP, its own strategic investment in Anthropic, and its consumer businesses."



The peril of laziness lost

Bryan Cantrill · bcantrill.dtrace.org

Oxide Computer co-founder Bryan Cantrill warns that LLMs could erode one of the most important programmer virtues: principled laziness. "LLMs inherently lack the virtue of laziness. Work costs nothing to an LLM. LLMs do not feel a need to optimize for their own (or anyone's) future time, and will happily dump more and more onto a layercake of garbage. Left unchecked, LLMs will make systems larger, not better."

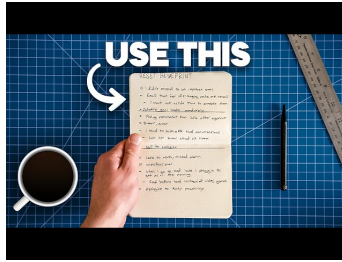


Sam Altman

samaltman.com · Sam Altman

After an arson attempt at his home, OpenAI's Sam Altman reflects on power and AGI while calling for healthy debate about what AI's future should look like. "While we have that debate, we should de-escalate the rhetoric and tactics and try to have fewer explosions in fewer homes, figuratively and literally."

Most highlighted YouTube Video of the week



The Blueprint to Reset Your Life

Bullet Journal

Turn mistakes into a blueprint for change with Bullet Journal creator Ryder Carroll.

"Punishment is not the same thing as accountability. It's actually a lack thereof. Beating yourself up feels like you're doing something, but it changes nothing. You're just doubling down on an identity that you don't want."

Most highlighted Twitter Thread of the week



Thin Harness, Fat Skills

Garry Tan

Y Combinator president Garry Tan unpacks the architectural pattern behind the leap from 2x to 100x AI productivity: a robust, ever-evolving set of skills. "Every skill you write is a permanent upgrade to your system. It never degrades. It never forgets. It runs at 3 AM while you sleep. And when the next model drops, every skill instantly gets better — the judgment in the latent steps improves while the deterministic steps stay perfectly reliable."

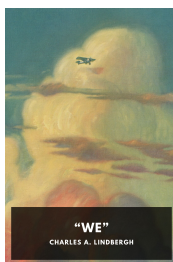
Most highlighted PDF of the week

System Card: Claude Mythos Preview

Anthropic

Anthropic's system card for the unreleased Claude Mythos Preview explains why its most capable model stays off the market. "Claude Mythos Preview demonstrated a striking leap in cyber capabilities relative to prior models, including the ability to autonomously discover and exploit zero-day vulnerabilities in major operating systems and web browsers."

Hand-picked book of the week



"We"

Charles Lindbergh

Charles Lindbergh's autobiography traces his path from stunt-flying barnstormer to aviation legend, culminating in his historic 1927 solo transatlantic flight aboard the *Spirit of St. Louis*. In "We", Lindbergh recounts the discipline, endurance, and nerve that carried him alone across the Atlantic, offering a firsthand view of one of the most celebrated journeys in aviation history.

"Darkness set in about 8:15 and a thin, low fog formed over the sea through which the white bergs showed up with surprising clearness. For nearly two hours I flew entirely blind through the fog at an altitude of about 1,500 feet."

This edition of "We" is available through Standard Ebooks. You can explore their ever-expanding collection of high-quality, carefully formatted, and free public domain ebooks [here](#).

Handpicked RSS feed of the week



between two seas

Evolutionary biologist Rebecca Hooper writes *between two seas*, a Substack from off the coast of Scotland about science, life, and wonder. From barnacles in space: "From miniscule larvae, rudderless in the open ocean and swept to wherever the currents take them, barnacles crawl across rocks in search of others and there, tucking much closer to the group than their basic needs suggest they should, they build their permanent home."

How to hire people who are better than you

JASON COHEN · 19 APR 2026 · SOURCE

If you don't hire people better than you, the organization gets bigger, not better. But how do you hire for something you don't understand?



"Thanks for coming in, but we're looking for less of a sales manager, and more of a leader of the pack."

Probably this VP of Marketing you're interviewing is full of shit. I mean, they're in marketing, that's what they're good at, right? Except, if that's what they're supposed to be good at, maybe it's good that they're doing that? But also, maybe they're *not* full of shit. You have no idea, because you have no idea how to hire a VP of Marketing.

Because you're an engineer whose entire marketing experience is some half-assed AdWords campaigns that taught you nothing except how fast money disappears when you don't know what you're doing. But you're the CEO, and you (correctly) decided it's time to hire someone who can actually build a marketing department and then hold them accountable for a job you don't understand. You need this hire precisely because you can't do what they do. But that also means you can't tell whether they can do it.

It's like evaluating a pancreatic surgeon. What do you ask? What do you do with the answer?

But you have no choice: you *must* hire people who are better than you at every position—that's the only way the organization grows stronger and smarter and better rather than just growing larger. Without it, organizations get worse with size—more overhead, more meetings, more communication cost, without commensurate improvement in individual capability. And a great person isn't 10x better than an average one—they're infinitely better, because they come up with ideas and implementations that a hundred average people never would.

Early on, the CEO is the best person at the company at *some* things—maybe sales from passion, maybe product from vision. But by a hundred people, if the CEO is still better than everyone at *anything*, the CEO has hired poorly, and the company is suffering. I've already written about why you must hire up—why delegation alone produces a team that's never better than the founder. This is the companion piece: *how* you evaluate candidates who know more than you, in areas you don't understand.

Since you can't assess their domain expertise, here's what you're looking for instead.

You leave wanting to implement their ideas

After the conversation, do you find yourself thinking: “Even if we don't hire them, we've got to do half of the things they said.” Maybe you're so excited you start working on it right away.

You can't verify whether their advice is *actually* wise. But this feeling means their ideas connected with you on a deep level; this means that at minimum it's a culture-fit, which is already a substantial finding. The ideas make sense in your situation, with your constraints, so at least they are plausible. Your excitement is more meaningful than you give it credit for.

Genuine expertise produces specific, actionable ideas that feel tailor-made to your context. People who just talk a good game will say things that sound impressive—and might even be true in a broad sense—but will leave you thinking “is that really what grown-up Marketing is?” and not “Hell yes that’s what I want this company to be like.”

If they change how you think about your own company in an hour, imagine what they could do in a year.

The inverse is just as telling. A candidate who speaks fluently about marketing frameworks but never connects them to the specific challenges you described five minutes ago is just parroting stuff they’ve seen and heard. ChatGPT can do that too, and you have just as little confidence that it’s right for you. You’re looking for someone who was born for *this* job, not someone performing the generic version of it. The difference is unmistakable once you’ve felt it, and you don’t need domain knowledge to feel it.

Ask yourself this: If they instead went to work for your competitor, would that worry you? Do you think: Uh oh, now we’re dead? Or do you think: I’m not sure *what* they would do for that competitor?

You’re already learning from them—and so would everyone else

Zuckerberg is famous for his hiring rule for executives:

“I always tell people that you should only hire people to be on your team if you would work for them.”

It sounds great but it’s not true literally—Zuckerberg would never, and has never, worked for anyone else. But if we take the spirit of his idea and apply it to things that actually happen—things you can look for—it becomes an excellent test.

The weakest version is: If you wouldn’t be comfortable working for this person, you’re hiring out of expediency, not quality.

Much better is: Would you learn from this person? Would others at the company learn? In my experience this is not only true of every great executive, but it’s so clearly true that you can tell from the interview. You can tell, because it’s already happened. They’ve already said something you didn’t know, that piqued your interest. You checked it afterwards, and you feel down rabbit holes you never new existed. But they did, and this candidate already knew about them. That’s the signal.

The real test—and an actual executive job duty, even if the job description doesn't say so—if you took a six-month sabbatical and never checked in, when you returned would the department be *measurably better* under their leadership? That means: processes improved, team stronger, output higher?

That's what "lift" looks like: Hiring someone who takes work away from you, who creates a better department than you were creating, where the company is improving all around you because you hired people who know how to do that. That's the job. Your job isn't to also know all those things; it's to hire people who do, which means hiring people who you're already learning from.

They will elevate the whole organization

Great leaders don't improve their silo only—they're better at people issues, communication, decision-making, goal-setting, annual planning, org structure—things that are useful everywhere in the company, not just in their department. A great VP Marketing will never be able to contribute to your Typescript-specific `CLAUDE.md`, but they will have theories about how to grow from three to thirty teams, or how to set annual goals but keep people focused on what's happening now, or how to communicate difficult news to the entire company, or how to know when it's finally time to implement certain "big company" policies, or how to structure an two-day strategic retreat, or how to handle a difficult situation between two employees, or how to run human performance management as objectively and humanely as possible.

These are all things you can test for during the interview, by asking how they handle these situations. Which situations exactly? Use some that you're facing today, or just faced, or heard about on a forum that you're scared will happen to you soon. Not as their domain of expertise, but as a leader in a company.

Ask them to solve a real problem you face

Give them an actual challenge from your company. If you're struggling with goal-setting, ask how they'd implement that in a culture that's never had goals; if you have high churn, ask how they'd diagnose the cause; if employee turnover is high, ask how they'd figure out what's going on when people are reluctant to explain themselves.

You're not evaluating the details of the answer—you don't know how—you're watching how they think, and what direct experience they have. Do they ask incisive, clarifying questions that make you feel like they deeply understand what you're going through? Do they acknowledge

what they don't yet know? Do they not only name a framework but explain how they applied it? Is there any indication they actually did any of that themselves, or are they just parroting blog posts?

Use reference checks to evaluate culture fit, not expertise

Standard reference checks are useless for evaluating expertise—candidates hand you friendlies primed to say nice things, and there's no value in sanitized endorsements. But reference checks are powerful for evaluating whether this person will thrive *here*, in *this* company, at *this* stage—which is what matters for a leadership hire where you can't evaluate domain expertise anyway.

Instead of the usual questions, I ask this:

What is the ideal scenario under which this person thrives?

That is: Construct the absolutely perfect set of circumstances—subject matter, goal, team (or lack thereof), direction (or lack thereof), incentives, etc.—where this person absolutely kills it, is efficient, is productive, is happy, and makes everyone around them happy.

If they say “Oh yeah, that person needs a goal because they want to know what ‘success’ looks like, but then get out of their way because they're creative and they explore quickly,” then you extract personal attributes like “goal-oriented” and “craves exploration.” In that case, working on a mature product might be a bad fit, but an early-stage startup might be ideal.

Then ask the opposite:

Construct the scenario where they die inside, mess everything up, and piss everyone off.

It's funny to ask and easy for the other person to answer, but it doesn't feel like negativity—after all, we all have a personal hell.

One more:

What are their strengths that they're unaware of because they come so naturally to them? Where they don't realize other people aren't like that too?

These are a person's most natural, powerful abilities—they can't help but be great at them, yet they're special. The person can't see them, by definition, because they don't realize how unusual they are. Others know. They are some of their most annoying and endearing qualities. And for your purposes, these answers tell you whether this person will thrive in your specific environment—your pace, your chaos, your culture—better than any credential or case study ever could.

Why this focus on strengths? Because everyone has weaknesses; you're not looking for someone without weaknesses. Rather, you need someone who has a few special strengths *that your company needs right now*. Not just competence, but superpowers. That's what's going to make the difference between “filling the seat” and making an impact.

You'll still get it wrong sometimes

Like everyone else, I've hired people who were great in interviews and couldn't really do the job, and people who were unimpressive in interviews and crushed it for ten years. Only one of those errors is costly. A false negative costs you a continued search. A false positive hurts the team, delays getting the right person in, and is terrible for the person you hired—they might have quit a job; how long will their next search take? If this happens a lot, you have to fix yourself.

Still, what choice do you have? You have to take a bet.

What you do control is what happens after a mis-hire. You decide whether you let that linger for a year, pissing off your best people—who are most capable of finding another job—delaying the development of that department, not solving whatever it is you hired them to solve.

If you feel like it's easier to just do it yourself, you hired incorrectly. If your best people are complaining all the time instead of being inspired, you hired incorrectly. If things don't start improving immediately, you hired incorrectly.

Everyone else on the team knows it—sooner than you, because they are experiencing it more acutely than you—and yet you are the only one who can fix it. Make the break cleanly. Act immediately; you're already three months late.

The interview is about the person, not the details

You went into the interview with the VP of Marketing trying to figure out whether they're good at marketing. But you can't evaluate that.

Even a year from now, you still won't know if their demand-gen strategy was optimal or if a different hire would have grown revenue faster. You will never have the counterfactual.

What you *will* know is whether they changed how you see your own company—whether they found problems you didn't know were there, built things you didn't think to build, and made the people around them, including you, sharper than before.

Those clues were available to you during the interview. The culture fit was available to you in the reference checks.

It's not perfect, but that's what you do.

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